“He's Fine. Why Would We Write This Down Now?”

Eight questions families ask about recording a parent's preferences, answered plainly.

Dad is independent, and you'd like to write down how he likes things while it's easy to ask. These are the questions families tend to have about doing that, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Dad in particular. Where a question needs him, or someone who knows his health, the answer says who to ask.

1 He's fine. Why would we write this down now?

Because he's fine. A calm stretch is when Dad has time to tell the story behind an answer and you have time to hear it. You don't need a reason, a date or a decision to write down how he likes his days. AARP's planning guide for families notes that it never seems like the right time for a conversation like this, and that you may be surprised to find your loved one has been meaning to have it too. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what's really on your mind is a change you've noticed in him. That's a different question, and it belongs to Dad and his doctor.

2 What makes an ordinary day enjoyable, and how do we find out?

Ask him, and expect small answers. The Conversation Project's workbook puts the question as “What does a good day look like for you?” and offers examples as plain as getting up and dressed, making a phone call and having coffee with a friend. He may not think the small things are worth mentioning. Write them down anyway, the way he says them. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** he mentions that something he enjoys has become hard to do. Write down what he said and suggest he bring it up with his doctor. Don't work out the reason yourselves.

3 What should a future caregiver understand about him?

Whatever Dad would want them to understand, which is why the question goes to him. For a sense of the range, a form the Alzheimer's Association publishes for telling others about a person asks for a preferred name, a typical day and any established routines, likes and dislikes, and what the person finds calming. The federal Administration for Community Living lists recreation, friendships, family relationships and social activities among the preferences that person-centered planning takes in. Neither is a list of what has to be covered. [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you ever want to know what a particular agency or community would ask for. That's a question for them, and nothing here can answer it.

4 How do we ask without it feeling like an interview?

Don't hold one. Use the conversations you already have, a meal or a drive, and ask one or two things at a time. The Conversation Project's workbook tells helpers to take it in small pieces, that it's always okay to skip a question, and to let the person pick the questions that appeal to them. AARP's guide adds: be open and, most importantly, listen. [2] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Dad would sooner talk about this with someone outside the family. Some people would. Mention it to your care consultant or his doctor's office and ask what they suggest.

5 “Dad doesn't eat fish.” Is that a preference?

It might be a taste, a habit, an allergy or something a doctor told him, and the family may not agree on which. They aren't interchangeable. MedlinePlus, from the National Library of Medicine, describes a food allergy as an abnormal immune system reaction to certain foods, which makes it a medical matter and not a dislike. So ask Dad where it comes from, and keep three lists: what he likes and dislikes, any allergy the family has been told about, and anything a clinician has told him to eat or avoid. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** nobody, Dad included, is sure which list something belongs on. His doctor or pharmacist can say. The family shouldn't settle it.

6 What if what he tells us isn't what we thought, or isn't what we think is best?

Then you've learned something, which is the point of asking. Write his version down as his. If the family sees it differently, that can go on the page too, labeled as the family's view. AARP's guide says a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care. A fact sheet for families of nursing home residents, from the National Consumer Voice, says a resident's preferences may be different than what you think is best, but the resident's needs and wishes should always be respected. [1] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family can't leave a disagreement as two notes side by side. Bring both versions to your care consultant. Don't settle it by leaving one of them off the page.

7 How should we keep his preferences current?

Date the page, and agree with Dad on when you'll go over it again. A note in the calendar for next year is enough, with another look after a big change such as a move. The Conversation Project's workbook says people's preferences often change as their health changes or as time goes by, and suggests revisiting the answers. We found no public source that sets a schedule, so the timing is yours and his to choose. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** his health changes and you're not sure something on the page still suits him. Ask him first. Anything about diet or a medical instruction goes to his clinician.

8 Who gets to see what we've written?

That's for Dad to say. It's a page about him, so ask who he's comfortable having read it and write his answer at the bottom, next to the date. People differ on this: the Conversation Project's workbook asks how much a person wants those close to them to know, on a scale that runs from not all the details to all of them. Nothing needs sharing with anyone outside the family now. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** there's a reason to share it with someone outside the family. When and with whom is something your care consultant helps a family think through, and the choice is still Dad's.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Dad himself: what he prefers, what he'd want in a situation he hasn't talked about, or what any food or health instruction means for him. Those answers come from him and from his clinicians. The Alzheimer's Association form was written with dementia care in mind and the Consumer Voice fact sheet for families of nursing home residents; we've drawn only on their everyday points, and nothing here assumes either applies to Dad.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions about asking Dad and writing it down. The care interview is where the questions become about him: it walks you through his situation area by area, his preferences among them, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
3. Alzheimer's Association, Personal Facts and Insights (form)
4. Administration for Community Living, Person-Centered Planning
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Food Allergy
6. National Consumer Voice for Quality Long-Term Care, Family Involvement in Nursing Homes (fact sheet)
